Our Long Car Ride Survival Kit (Tested on a 6-Hour Drive)

October 9, 2026 · 3 min read

We drove six hours to my in-laws last month. Two kids in the back: a 4-year-old and a 2-year-old. I packed the car the night before like I was preparing for an expedition, and honestly half of it was useless.

What actually worked:

The snack tackle box. I bought one of those plastic tackle boxes with the little compartments and filled each one with something different: raisins, cheese cubes, crackers, blueberries, pretzels, those yogurt melts. It took me twenty minutes to fill and it bought us two full hours. They treated it like a treasure chest. My 4-year-old kept announcing "I'm opening number seven!" like it was a game show.

Audiobooks. Specifically, a silly one about a pigeon driving a bus — my son has it memorized and yells the lines before they happen. We listened to the whole thing twice. When the 2-year-old got restless I'd skip to the funny parts.

The surprise bag. I wrapped five cheap things — a tiny dinosaur, stickers, a bouncy ball, a new crayon pack, a little notebook — in newspaper, one for each hour. Handing over a crinkly package reset the mood every single time. Total cost: maybe six euros.

What flopped, and I mean really flopped:

The tablet. I charged it, loaded it with shows, bought the headrest mount. It died forty minutes in because I'd forgotten the mount blocks the charging port. My daughter stared at the black screen and said "it's broken" in the saddest voice, and I had no fix.

Coloring books. Great idea in theory. In practice, every crayon rolled under the seats within ten minutes and my son spent half an hour wailing for the blue one specifically. The blue one.

I also packed way too many stuffed animals. They ended up on the floor, and then someone cried because Bunny was “sleeping in the dirt.”

The backseat rules that kept everyone sane:

1. Nothing leaves your hands except into the snack box. Translation: no throwing things at your sister.
2. When the baby sleeps, we whisper. My 4-year-old took this SO seriously she shushed me at a rest stop.
3. We stop every two hours whether anyone needs the toilet or not. Non-negotiable. Every time we skipped a stop to “make good time,” someone had an accident or a meltdown within twenty minutes. Every time.

The drive wasn’t peaceful. There was a solid stretch around hour four where both kids cried at once because the 2-year-old dropped her water cup and the 4-year-old was mad we wouldn’t stop for ice cream. But nobody cried for more than ten minutes straight, we arrived with everyone mostly intact, and my mother-in-law said “that wasn’t so bad” — which, from her, is a standing ovation.